





Infantry and specialists
The increasing emphasis on trenches and other field fortifications during the Civil War meant specialists such as these engineers from the 8th New York State Militia (*right*) played a vital role in both Union and Confederate armies. A regular Union infantryman in forage cap (*far right*) sips water from his canteen during a Civil War re-enactment.

> "I HAVE A MORTAL DREAD OF THE BATTLEFIELD ... I AM AFRAID THAT THE GROANS OF THE WOUNDED AND DYING WILL MAKE ME SHAKE, NEVERTHELESS I HOPE AND TRUST THAT STRENGTH WILL BE GIVEN ME TO STAND AND DO MY DUTY."
>
> **PRIVATE EDWARD EDES,** LETTER TO HIS FATHER BEFORE FIRST ENTERING COMBAT, APRIL 1863

At the same time as introducing conscription, the government set about encouraging the volunteers of 1861 to stay in the army when their three-year term was up. War-weariness was rife among the men – many of whom had had no home leave since enlisting – but with the aid of the promise of a 30-day leave of absence, some 200,000 were induced to extend their service to the war's end.

A gulf separated these proud "Veteran Volunteers" from the later recruits, bounty men and substitutes, generally dredged from the poorest sectors of society by the lure of cash. sA private, Frank Wilkeson, described them as "conscienceless and cowardly scoundrels" whom "clean-minded American and Irish and German volunteers would not associate with". Desertion rates had always been high in the Union army, men drifting away to cope with difficulties back home or discouraged with the soldiering experience. But the bounty men or substitutes were notorious for disappearing as soon as they received their lump sum. General Ulysses Grant complained in September 1864: "The men we have been getting in this way almost all desert."

BATTLING THROUGH

Yet whatever their changing nature – from the naive volunteers of 1861 to the mix of hardened fighters and poor-quality recruits of the latter stages of the conflict – the Union infantry were the men who ultimately won the war. Cavalry performed a useful function as scouts and raiders. Artillery inflicted a high percentage of combat casualties. But battles were decided by the success or failure of waves of infantry advancing in the face of withering defensive fire.

Soldiers on both sides used the Springfield or Enfield rifle-musket, a muzzle-loading firearm which was fired by using a percussion cap. This was a step forward from the unrifled flintlock musket of the Napoleonic era in rate of fire, range, and accuracy. Since cannon were also significantly more effective than those used at Waterloo, infantry out in the open were certain to take heavy casualties. In the course of the war, soldiers learned either to take up defensive positions that exploited existing cover such as stone walls or ditches, or to construct earth

Tobacco
Licensed vendors known as sutlers travelled with the army in the field, selling everything from writing paper to whisky and tobacco. The pipe bowl shown here is hand carved – a popular pastime for bored soldiers.



FIGHTING IN THE TRENCHES

The intensification of infantry and artillery firepower as the Civil War went on increasingly led armies to resort to field fortifications. In the static warfare around Vicksburg in 1863 and around Petersburg in 1864–65, these developed into extensive trench systems – at Petersburg the trenches stretched for some 50km (30 miles). Inevitably in retrospect the Civil War trenches are seen as pointing forward to the stalemate on the Western Front in World War I.

SAPPERS AND MINERS

Entrenchment had been a familiar feature of siege warfare since the 17th century and before. Civil War armies deployed traditional siege weaponry, including mortars and grenades. Also in the siege tradition, Union engineers dug a tunnel under the Confederate lines outside Petersburg and exploded four tons of gunpowder in it, creating a vast crater which, however, Union soldiers were unable to exploit. Trench warfare was demoralizing for both sides. Soldiers were subject to boredom, disease, and the steady attrition of sniper and mortar fire.